THE RETAKE METHOD

Exam technique for candidates retaking a professional licensing exam



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Free sample

THE RETAKE METHOD

Exam technique for candidates retaking a professional licensing exam

This sample contains the contents, the opening of the book and one full chapter ("Chapter 8. Tie-breakers between two plausible options"), exactly as they appear in the full book. The full book has 97 pages. Page numbers in the contents refer to the full book.

Get the full book:

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Contents

Chapter 1 How to use this book 6

Chapter 2 What a failed attempt tells you, and what it does not 9

Chapter 3 Why people fail a retake: three causes 12

Chapter 4 Reading your score report, word for word 16

Chapter 5 Method gap or knowledge gap: the diagnostic 22

Chapter 6 The anatomy of a question 27

Chapter 7 FIRST, NEXT, BEST and MOST LIKELY: the decision rules 33

Chapter 8 Tie-breakers between two plausible options 40

Chapter 9 Elimination, and when not to change an answer 47

Chapter 10 Pacing: setting the clock per question 51

Chapter 11 What to say to yourself when you are stuck or panicking 57

Chapter 12 The retake conversation with your employer or supervisor 62

Chapter 13 The retake conversation with family and partner 67

Chapter 14 Your practice error log 71

Chapter 15 A retake study week built on method 75

Chapter 16 The exam-day routine 79

Chapter 17 The last ten minutes 83

Chapter 18 After the result: the next 24 hours, week and month 87

Conclusion: the habits that carry over 91

Recommended next steps and further resources 93

About the publisher 96

Copyright 97

CHAPTER 1

How to use this book

You sat a professional licensing exam, and the result was not the one you wanted. Maybe it was close. Maybe it was not close at all. Maybe this is the second or third time. Either way, a retake is booked or about to be, and you have probably already done the obvious thing, which is to open the same books again and start rereading.

This book is about the other half of the problem. It does not teach your subject. It teaches you how to sit the exam: how to read what your failed score report actually says, how to decide between two answers that both look right, how to hold a steady pace, what to say to yourself when your mind goes blank, and how to have the conversations at work and at home that make a second attempt possible at all.

Who this book is for

It is written for one reader: an adult who has failed a professional licensing exam once or more, in any field, and who has a multiple-choice retake booked or planned. You might work in health, finance, engineering, design, a trade, or anything else that ends with a licence. The method does not depend on the field, because it is about questions, time and nerves, and those work the same way in every exam room.

If your exam is oral, practical or essay-only, this is not the right book. If you want subject content, practice questions or a promise of a result, this is not the right book either, and it says so now rather than after you have read it. This book is independent: it is not affiliated with, endorsed by or approved by any examination body, licensing authority or professional body.

What you will be able to do

By the end you will be able to do six things. Turn a failed score report into a diagnosis you can act on. Apply a fixed rule to questions that ask for the FIRST, NEXT, BEST or MOST LIKELY answer. Break a tie between two plausible options without guessing. Hold a pace per question that you worked out from your own exam's rules. Hold the retake conversation with your employer and your family. And run an exam-day routine, including a routine for the last ten minutes.

None of that replaces knowing your material. It makes sure that what you know reaches the answer sheet. It does not promise or guarantee any examination result.

Read it in this order

Chapters 2 to 5 are about understanding what happened. Do not skip them. The rest of the book only helps if you know which kind of problem you are fixing, and chapter 5 is where you find out.

Chapters 6 to 10 are the method in the exam room: how questions are built, how to decide, how to eliminate, and how to pace.

Chapters 11 to 13 are about people, starting with yourself. They are mostly scripts: the actual words, ready to use.

Chapters 14 to 18 are the practical tools: an error log, a study week, the exam-day routine, the last ten minutes, and what to do after the result arrives.

Read it once straight through. Then work through it again with your own score report and a practice set beside you. Reading about method feels like learning it. Using it on practice material is what actually changes how you sit the exam.

What this book will not do

It will not give you exam content of any kind. It will not tell you how many times you may sit your exam, how long you must wait between attempts, or what a retake costs, because those rules belong to your exam body and they change. When a rule matters, this book tells you to check it in your exam body's published information, and that is where you should take it from.

It is exam-agnostic. Your exam has its own length, its own time limit, its own rules on flagging and reviewing answers, and its own score report. You will adapt every technique here to those rules, and the book shows you how.

A word about the examples

Every worked example in this book is invented. The questions are set in kitchens, on bicycles and on journeys, on purpose, so that no example can be mistaken for the subject matter of any profession. None of them is an examination question, and none is drawn from any examination. The same goes for Dana, the hypothetical candidate who appears in several chapters, and for the hypothetical exam she sits: both are made up to show the method working.

CHAPTER 8

Tie-breakers between two plausible options

You have read the question, applied the rule, and eliminated two options. Two remain, and both look right. This is the moment many retake candidates lose the most points, because they fall back on gut feeling, and gut feeling under pressure is mostly noise.

What follows is a fixed sequence of questions. Ask them in order, as lines you say to yourself, and stop as soon as one of them separates the two options. If none does, the last step tells you what to do.

These steps are habits of careful thinking, not rules of any exam. Where your exam's own instructions or conventions differ, they take precedence.

Step one: restate the question

> "What exactly is this question asking? Let me say the lead-in in my own words."

Many ties are not real ties. They are two options that answer two slightly different questions, and only one of those is the question on the screen. Saying the lead-in in your own words, out loud in your head, often makes one option fall away immediately.

Step two: check the qualifier again

> "What is the qualifier, and what does its rule say?"

Apply the rule from chapter 7 again, deliberately, to just these two options. If it is a FIRST question, ask which one has to happen before the other. If it is a BEST question, ask which one meets every goal and limit. Ties often break here, because the first time through you applied the rule to four options at once.

Step three: use every fact

> "Which option uses every fact in the stem? Is there a fact that one of these options ignores?"

Go back to the stem and list the facts. Then check each option against each fact. Often one option fits all the facts except one, and that one fact was put there precisely to rule it out.

Step four: check whether one contains the other

> "Is one of these options part of the other?"

Sometimes one option is a specific action and the other is a broader action that includes it. On a BEST question, the broader and more complete option is usually stronger, as long as it stays within the stem. On a FIRST or NEXT question, the narrower, earlier step is usually the answer, because the broader option describes a whole process rather than its first move.

Step five: check for assumptions

> "Does either option need something to be true that the stem does not say?"

If an option only works on an assumption, such as that the person has a tool the stem never mentions, or that a fact is different from how the stem gives it, prefer the other option. Exam questions are built so that the keyed answer works on the facts given.

Step six: check for extremes

> "Is either option absolute where the situation calls for judgement?"

Words such as "all", "none", "immediately stop everything" or "under no circumstances" make an option fragile. If the other option is measured and fits the facts, prefer it. If both are measured, this step does not help; go on.

Step seven: defend each in one sentence

> "Can I defend each option in one sentence, using only the stem?"

Try it. Say: "Option B is right because..." and finish the sentence using only facts from the stem. Then do the same for the other. The option whose sentence comes easily and uses the stem's facts is the stronger one. If one sentence needs "probably" or "unless" or an outside assumption, that option is weaker.

Step eight: choose, flag, move

> "I have done the steps. I choose this one, I flag it, and I move on."

If all seven steps leave you with a genuine tie, stop spending time. Choose the option that won more of the steps, flag the question if your exam allows it, and go to the next question. A tie that has survived seven checks will rarely break by staring at it, and the time is worth more on the next question.

The full sequence, as a list you can learn

Learn these eight lines until you can say them without looking:

- "What exactly is this asking?"
- "What is the qualifier, and what does its rule say?"
- "Which option uses every fact?"
- "Is one inside the other?"
- "Does either need an assumption?"
- "Is either extreme?"
- "Can I defend each in one sentence?"
- "Choose, flag, move."

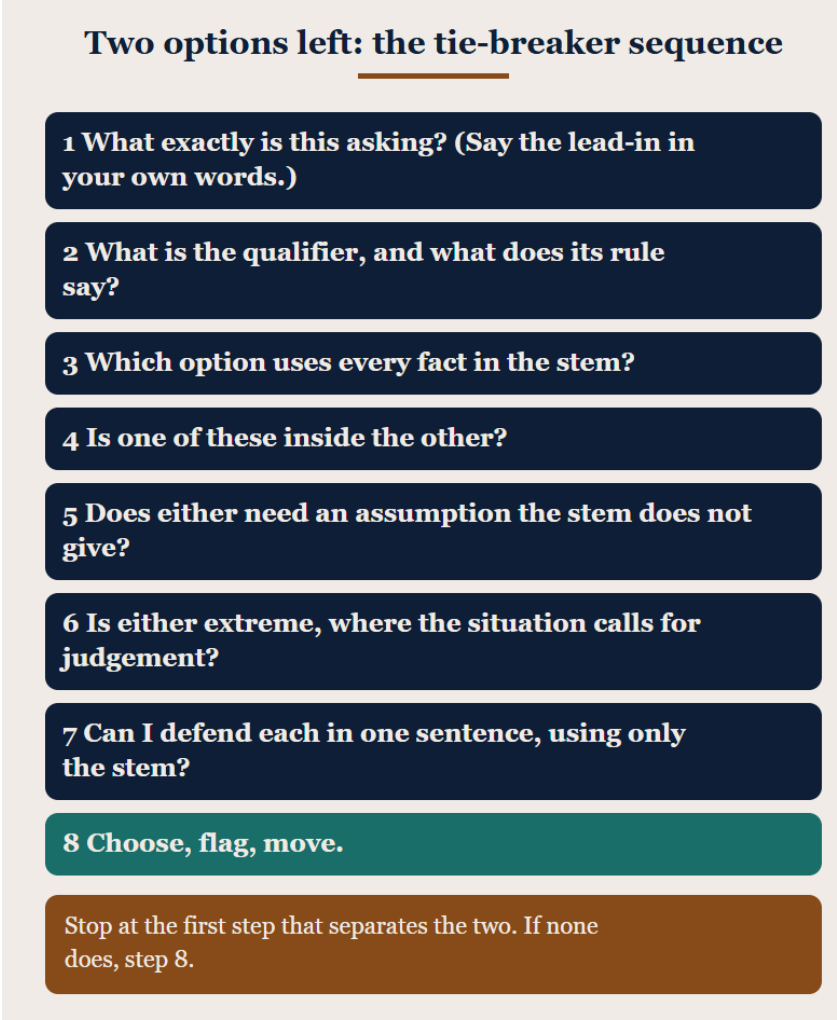


Figure 4. The eight tie-breaker lines, in the order to ask them.

A worked example

An invented travel question. Suppose you have already struck out two other options, and these two remain.

> **Question.** You are planning a day trip by car to a coastal town to walk along the cliffs. The forecast is for heavy rain from about midday, and the cliff path is closed to

walkers whenever it is wet. You must be home by 6 pm. What is the BEST plan?

- **A.** Leave at 7 am, walk the cliff path in the morning, spend the afternoon in the town, and drive home in time.
- **B.** Leave at 7 am, walk the cliff path in the morning, have lunch in the town, walk the path again in the afternoon, and drive home in time.

Both look right. Run the steps.

Step one. What is it asking? The best plan to walk the cliffs, given the weather and the deadline.

Step two. The qualifier is BEST: all goals, all limits. The goal is to walk the cliffs. The limit you notice first is being home by 6 pm. Both options meet the goal and that limit, so at a glance the rule does not separate them. Go on.

Step three. List the facts: rain from about midday, the path closed when wet, home by 6 pm. A uses all three: it puts the walk before the rain and uses the afternoon for something that does not need the path. B ignores two of them: its afternoon walk falls when it is raining and the path is closed. One fact was put there to rule out one option, and this tie breaks here. You stop; steps four to eight are not needed.

Answer: A. As a check, step seven: "A is best because it fits the walk before the rain and respects the deadline." That uses only the stem. "B is best because..." cannot be finished without ignoring the closed path.

Notice why B was tempting. It looks more complete, with two walks. The guideline in step four, that the more complete option is usually stronger on a BEST question, holds only while the option stays within the facts of the stem.

Practising the tie-breakers

On your next three practice sets, every time you are torn between two options, write which step broke the tie. After a few sets, you will notice that the same two or three steps do most of the work for you. Those are the ones to say first in the exam.